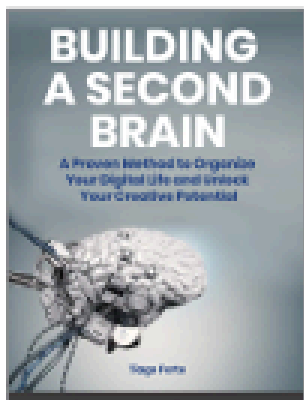




BUILDING A SECOND BRAIN

A Proven Method to Organize Your Digital Life
and Unlock Your Creative Potential

TIAGO FORTE



The Big “So What”

All of us have moments when we struggle to absorb new information or recall something important. [This step-by-step guide explains how to build a Second Brain—a digital information management system—to remember, retrieve and fully utilize all sorts of information. This improves your productivity, your creativity, and your ability to achieve any goal.](#)



The Second Brain: What it is and why we need it



We live in an information age where we're surrounded by useful data. Yet, we don't retain much of what we read or consume, and struggle to remember important facts and information. Tiago Forte created the Second Brain system to help him capture and manage information in various aspects of his life. This book is the culmination of what he learned after 10 years of research, experimentation, and teaching others to build their knowledge management systems.

- A Second Brain is like an external brain where you can store and manage useful information. It's similar to an external hard drive for a computer, or a digital pocket library that contains all the information you want to remember.
- Forte's system leverages technology to digitize note-taking and organize information (including images, links, and all sorts of files). The content can be backed up online, searched and synced across multiple devices, to create a “knowledge vault” or a central source of information. It gives you the assurance that all your ideas are safely preserved.

KEY QUOTES

“A Second Brain enables you to recall everything you might want to remember so you can achieve anything you desire.”

“So many of us share the feeling that we are surrounded by knowledge, yet starving for wisdom.”

“Technology doesn't just make notetaking more efficient. It transforms the very nature of notes.”

- Your Second Brain will probably be made up of a set of tools/apps—such as a note-taking app, calendar, email, to-do list, etc—to store/retrieve critical information. This freed up your mental capacity, so you can be more creative, productive, and focus your energy on achieving your goals in life.



Capabilities and Benefits of a Second Brain

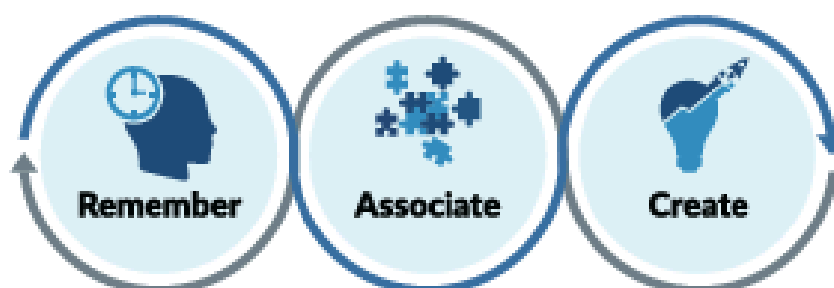


A Second Brain has 4 key capabilities you can rely on:

- It makes ideas tangible by giving them a visual, external form, making it easier to observe, rearrange, edit, or combine the ideas.
- It unveils connections between ideas. When diverse ideas are placed together, we're more likely to notice unusual patterns. We can also shuffle and combine the ideas creatively, like forming words in a game of Scrabble.
- It nurtures ideas over time. We tend to focus on ideas that are recent or accessible, regardless of their actual value. With a Second Brain, we can gather and incubate ideas to develop better insights and solutions over time.
- Often, we get stuck not because we lack skills/talent, but because we lack sufficient material to spark our imagination or convince others. The Second Brain provides a wealth of resources (e.g. stories, examples, images, statistics, quotes, analogies) to let you present your views and ideas convincingly.



Knowledge is the most valuable asset for modern professionals. A Second Brain helps you to manage personal knowledge in 3 stages.



- It serves as a memory aid to help you remember things (e.g. facts, important dates, project details), and retrieve them easily in the future.

KEY QUOTES

"Only when we declutter our brain of complex ideas can we think clearly and start to work with those ideas effectively."

"In its most practical form, creativity is about connecting ideas together, especially ideas that don't seem to be connected."

"If it feels like the well of inspiration has run dry, it's because you need a deeper well."

"Our intuitive mind learns, and responds, even without our conscious awareness."

- It serves as a thinking tool to help you associate ideas and see things from fresh perspectives.
- It serves as an innovation tool to help you combine different ideas and create something new and unique.

The CODE Method to Remember What Matters

The CODE System involves 4 steps—Capture, Organize, Distill, Express—to help you develop a Second Brain systematically.



1. Capture what Resonates

Save noteworthy information that resonates with you, and store them in a location you can control.



For centuries, intellectuals, artists and successful people have kept notebooks, sketchbooks, or journals where they recorded their thoughts and reflections. These served as personal knowledge banks where they could return to build on their content and ideas.

- For example, famous music artist, Taylor Swift, uses her phone to capture and edit lyrics, melodies and new song ideas on the go. Other songwriters often compile “hook books” of song lyrics and music, software engineers build “code libraries”, and lawyers keep “case files”.
- Recording knowledge in a concrete form yields several benefits:
 - (i) It's *easier to remember information* written in your own words;

KEY QUOTES

“Creative people are better at recognizing relationships, making associations and connections.”
—Nancy C. Andreasen

“Information isn't a luxury—it is the very basis of our survival.”

“Notetaking is the easiest and simplest way of externalizing our thinking. It requires no special skill, is private by default, and can be performed anytime and anywhere.”

- (ii) It's *easier to review ideas* objectively from a distance (instead of reacting impulsively to them); and
- (iii) It allows you to examine, connect and experiment with the ideas to *realize their full potential*.



A knowledge bank should contain both external and internal knowledge. These include:

- External content, e.g. highlights from your readings, digital bookmarks, meeting notes, or voice memos; and
- Internal content, e.g. insights, reflections, memories, random thoughts, or personal experiences.
- However, exclude sensitive information (e.g. passwords, tax records), or large/special format files (e.g. photoshop files).



To decide what to capture, consider if the content is (i) inspiring, (ii) useful, (iii) personal, and (iv) surprising enough to spark new ideas.

- Don't overanalyze it. Follow your intuition to decide if an idea is noteworthy and resonates with you. Identify the topics or problems that intrigue you the most, and let them guide you on what information to capture.
 - (i) Examine the things that fascinated you since young, and phrase them as open-ended questions.
 - (ii) Then, carry the list with you to fuel your curiosity, connect seemingly-unrelated ideas, and find novel solutions.
- Save only the most valuable parts of the content, and capture them succinctly using bullet points, quotes, or short sentences.
- Other useful information to capture include: links to the original sources, chapter titles, headings, publication dates, and even contradictory ideas that challenge your beliefs.



Here are some additional tips for capturing information:

- There are many tools you can use to record digital content easily. You can find a list of recommended tools on the author's website. Some examples include:

KEY QUOTES

"Thinking doesn't just produce writing; writing also enriches thinking."

"The more economical you can be with the material you capture in the first place, the less time and effort your future self will have to spend organizing, distilling, and expressing it."

KEY QUOTES

"Think of your capture tools as your extended nervous system, reaching out into the world to allow you to sense your surroundings."

- (i) Read-later apps to bookmark online content for review later;
 - (ii) Web-clipper apps to capture parts of web pages;
 - (iii) Audio/voice transcription apps and ebook apps for exporting transcribed text, notations or highlights;
 - (iv) Notes apps for saving text snippets; and
 - (v) Social media apps for "favoriting" and exporting content.
- The key is to consolidate your notes in 1 place. Ideally, choose a note-taking app that:
 - (i) Can store multimedia content (images, sketches, audios);
 - (ii) Is easy to use (no need for complex steps or formatting);
 - (iii) Is open-ended (so you can add content anytime);
 - (iv) Is action-oriented (i.e. you can jot down random thoughts).

There are many great apps like Microsoft OneNote, Google Keep, Apple Notes, Notion and Evernote. To keep things simple, start with an app you already have and upgrade it along the way.



2. Organize for Action

As you accumulate more notes, you'll need to organize them. **Categorize the materials according to the active projects that you're working on, or how they'll help to achieve your goals.**



Organize the information by purpose or action, not generic categories. This gives you greater clarity and motivation to move toward your goals.

- For example, famous dance choreographer Twyla Tharp uses labelled boxes as her Second Brain.
 - (i) Each time she starts a new choreography project, she writes its name clearly on a box, and specifies the goal upfront (e.g. "perfection" or "keep it simple") to keep herself on-track.
 - (ii) Whenever she comes across useful materials (e.g. pictures, videos, costume inspiration, personal ideas), she

"Organizing for action gives you a sense of tremendous clarity, because you know that everything you're keeping actually has a purpose."

deposits them in the relevant box. Thereafter, she can revisit the boxes anytime to work on a project or learn from past projects.



Forte created the PARA Organizing System to reflect 4 key types of information around us: Projects, Areas, Resources, and Archives. Use this system to file your information where it's the most useful or actionable.

- Projects are the short-term items that you're actively working on right now. These could be items that are on your to-do list, or just something on your mind to follow up on.
 - (i) Such projects could be work-related (e.g. creating a presentation slide deck), personal (e.g. planning your vacation), or side projects (e.g. researching a new sofa).
 - (ii) Each project comes with (a) a specific timeline and (b) concrete targets or outputs.
- Areas are personal or professional responsibilities to be managed over the long-term, e.g. health, finance, recruitment.
 - (i) These are not project-specific. They don't have specific goals or timeframes, and aren't immediately actionable.
 - (ii) However, they may include smaller projects, e.g. under the area "health", you may be working on a project to "lose 5 kg".
- References are topics or information that don't belong to a project/area, and aren't immediately actionable, but could be useful in the future. Examples include: hobbies/interests (e.g. poetry, movies, or home decor), research topics (e.g. nutrition or note-taking), and useful references (e.g. holiday gift ideas, stock photos).
- Archives are inactive items from the other 3 categories that you no longer use, e.g. finished projects or hobbies you've lost interest in. Move them to this container to organize your workspace without losing any information.



The PARA classification is universal, i.e. you can use it for *any* information. It's also arranged in order of actionability, with Projects being the most concrete and actionable.

- You can replicate this organizing system across multiple softwares, apps, or platforms. For example, you may use PARA

KEY QUOTES

"We don't need complex, sophisticated systems to be able to produce complex, sophisticated works."

"PARA isn't a filing system; it's a production system...The whole system is constantly shifting and changing in sync with your constantly changing life."

to label your 4 main folders or categories, and create unlimited number of sub-folders or sub-categories under each one.

- (i) When you finish a project, move it to your archives to clear your workspace (and consequently your mental space).
- (ii) Each time you start a new project, go through your archives to look for relevant materials from past projects.
- Your notes should evolve as your goals change. For example, you may initially file a note about coaching under "Resources" when you attend a course, but later move it to "Projects" when you're creating your own coaching program.
- The key is to create containers that are easy to understand, use, and maintain. Make sure that you can move the contents without losing them.



3. Distill the Essence

Our initial notes are like raw materials that must be processed and refined before they can become valuable assets. **Filter your notes down to their essence, so you can find, use and share the ideas easily in the future.**

-  Most ideas and information we acquire can't be used until much later. By the time we need those ideas, we've usually forgotten them, or can no longer find the idea amongst tons of notes. To keep ideas discoverable, we need to distill the core ideas into just 1-2 sentences, or a form that our future selves can find/grasp quickly. It's like how Einstein summarized his insights about energy into the well-known equation $E=MC^2$.

T You can use Forte's Progressive Summarization Technique to extract the most important points from your notes.

- Basically, you highlight your notes in layers using different formats (e.g. bold, underline):
 - (i) Highlight *chunks of text* in your raw notes, to help you revisit your notes in detail, or to find a specific point. Add a link to the original source for future reference.

KEY QUOTES

"PARA is a dynamic, constantly changing system, not a static one."

"Notetaking is like time travel—you are sending packets of knowledge through time to your future self."

(ii) Then, bold the *key words or phrases* that indicate what the note is about, what's the author's key message, or what resonates with you.

(iii) If the note is very long or important, add a 3rd layer by underlining *valuable points*.

(iv) If the note is truly valuable, add an *executive summary* in bullet points, using your own words. Put this at the top of your note so you can revisit it quickly.



- This approach allows you to retain the original details while making the key points more prominent. You can zoom in or zoom out depending on the amount of time and details you need, and there's no risk of losing important information as you distill the key points.



Each time you add highlights, headings, bullets, and comments to your notes, you're making your notes more discoverable and useful for your future self.

- Here are 3 rules of thumb for highlighting:
 - (i) Don't overthink the process. *Just go with your intuition* on what's important.
 - (ii) Highlight no more than 10-20% of the previous layer.
 - (iii) Don't start highlighting until you're clear on the *purpose* or what you'll use the notes for.
- In the book, Forte shows how this method can be used in a wide range of applications, from online articles to podcasts/ audios and meeting notes. Many top creative minds use distillation to enhance their art forms. For example:
 - (i) Renowned film director Francis Coppola has the habit of making notes as he reads a long storyline. He jots down his impressions and annotates the parts that resonate with him, before distilling and reconstructing them into unique ideas for directing blockbuster films.
 - (ii) In the painting *Picasso's Bull*, Pablo Picasso literally showed what it meant to deconstruct something down to its most essential form. He used a series of 11 images

KEY QUOTES

"Speed is everything when it comes to recall...the faster you can move through your notes, the more diverse and interesting ideas you can connect together."

"In making decisions about what to keep, we inevitably have to make decisions about what to throw away."

"As you distill your ideas, they naturally improve, because when you drop the merely good parts, the great parts can shine more brightly."

to portray a bull, including a version with layers of paint and a version where the bull was captured in just 1 simple, continuous line.



4. Express your Ideas

Show your work and test your ideas frequently to get feedback. Create a system to store and build on your intermediate work.



Information only becomes true knowledge when you apply it. Don't wait for complete or perfect information. Regularly test your ideas in small chunks, e.g. to critique or teach an idea, lobby for a cause, or create a solution.

- This allows you to gather feedback, and iteratively test/refine your ideas until you achieve your goals. The process also allows you to draw inspiration from external sources and combine them with your own ideas/experiences to create something new.
- For example, award-winning science-fiction writer Octavia Estelle Butler sought inspiration from her daily life, travels and readings. She always carried a notebook with her and recorded the smallest details, from her grocery lists to ideas for her stories. She distilled, modified, and added to those notes until they became masterpieces of science-fiction.



Your work-in-progress—including your notes, outlines, drafts, and feedback—contains valuable insights that could be reused in future. Use your Second Brain to capture these "Intermediate Packets" or IPs so they won't go to waste.

- Your IPs are the building blocks that make up your work. For example, a salesperson's work can be broken down into making calls, sending pitches, meeting clients, and closing deals.
- IPs can come in the form of online bookmarks, diary entries, social media content, old conference notes, etc. You can create and recycle at least 5 types of IPs:
 - (i) Notes that you've distilled from Step 3;
 - (ii) Ideas discarded from past projects;

KEY QUOTES

"Information becomes knowledge—personal, embodied, verified—only when we put it to use."

"If there is a secret to creativity, it is that it emerges from everyday efforts to gather and organize our influences."

*"Use what you have; even if it seems meager, it may be magic in your hands."
—Octavia Butler*

"[IPs reframe] creativity as an ongoing, continual cycle of delivering value in small bits, rather than a massive allconsuming endeavor that weighs on you for months."

KEY QUOTES

- (iii) Work-in-progress (e.g. graphics, plans) from past projects;
 - (iv) Completed work that you can use as a building block; and
 - (v) Documents or knowledge assets from others. You should give credit or acknowledge those sources in your final work.
- When you break down complex work into smaller IPs, it brings several benefits. You can:
 - (i) Focus your attention on 1 manageable chunk at a time;
 - (ii) Make use of small pockets of time to finish chunks of work;
 - (iii) Get more frequent feedback to improve your progress; and
 - (iv) Connect your IPs in creative ways, like LEGO blocks.
 - There are 4 ways to find or retrieve relevant IPs:
 - (i) Use the search feature in your notes app;
 - (ii) Browse your folders manually;
 - (iii) Create tags for your notes/materials (then search by tags); and
 - (iv) Rely on serendipity or calculated chances to find what you need. Scan at a broad level by looking across a range of projects, areas and resources, and selectively reviewing your notes. Look at saved images to tap into the visual parts of your brain, and share your ideas to get feedback and fresh perspectives.

"Like LEGO blocks, the more pieces you have, the easier it is to build something interesting."



Improving your Creative Process with CODE

Creativity doesn't happen randomly. The best creative minds strategize and develop habits that allow them to continually collect, process and combine raw materials to find new inspiration. By the time they sit down to create something, they already have the ingredients in place. **The 4-step CODE Method is designed to standardize how you work, so you can concurrently maximize your creativity and productivity.**

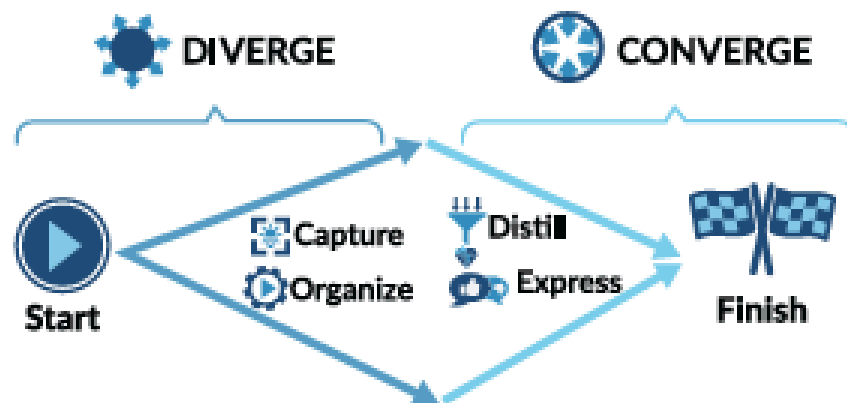
"Innovation and problem-solving depend on a routine that systematically brings interesting ideas to the surface of our awareness."



The Divergence-Convergence Loop



Every creative process involves alternating between divergence and convergence in an ongoing loop.



- Divergence is about expanding your possibilities by gathering a wide range of ideas/options and discussing them openly. This relates to the first 2 steps of the CODE method: to Capture and Organize ideas, so you can continually build on them.
- Convergence is about narrowing down your options to keep only what is essential/valuable, and use it to move toward your end-goal. This relates to the last 2 steps of the CODE method: to Distill and Express your ideas to create something new.
- For example, a writer diverges by researching facts/materials and developing potential characters. Then, she converges by drafting an outline, plot points and a first draft, before diverging again to add on new ideas or details.



You can use these 3 strategies to get started:

- Use the divergent mode to collect groups of ideas, then use the convergent mode to connect the clusters of ideas and organize them into a logical sequence. Do this digitally, as it's easier to edit, add links, add multimedia or interactive features, search for specific terms, and access the content from synced devices.
- Don't stop work only when you're totally exhausted. Reserve some energy to power up the next day's work. At the end of a work session, set aside some time to write down (i) where you're at, (ii) details to remember, (iii) ideas for your next steps, and (iv) what you intend to do next.

KEY QUOTES

"Instead of starting with scarcity, start with abundance—the abundance of interesting insights you've collected in your Second Brain."

This allows your mind to continue working on the task subconsciously, so you'll resume your work knowing exactly what to do. Ideally, share each day's IP for additional feedback.

- We tend to procrastinate when we're faced with an overlycomplex project. *Reduce the scope of your task* by parking the less important parts in your Second Brain. Focus on a small, manageable chunk, and retrieve the extra details later if required. For example, if you want to create a 4-week course, start by creating a free trial lesson.



Build 3 Habits To Keep Your Second Brain Organized



Use project checklists to start and end each project well, and to progressively build up the IPs/building blocks for future projects. Over time, the steps on the checklists should become second nature to you.

- Your project kickoff checklist could include:
 - (i) Recording your initial thoughts in a new project folder;
 - (ii) Searching/reviewing old folders to extract useful material;
 - (iii) Transferring useful notes to the current project folder;
 - (iv) Outlining the project;
 - (v) Defining your success criteria;
 - (vi) Doing a pre-mortem to consider what you wish to learn and the potential risks/challenges you may face; and
 - (vii) Communicating with your stakeholders to launch the project.
- At the end of a project, decide what information can be reused in the future and what to archive. Your project completion checklist could include:
 - (i) Checking off the project in your apps/lists, and marking the associated goals as "completed";
 - (ii) Reviewing the project IPs and moving them to relevant PARA folders;

KEY QUOTES

"There are habits that can help us be more organized so that our creativity has space to arise."

"Being organized is a habit—a repeated set of actions you take as you encounter, work with, and put information to use."

"Building a Second Brain...is about adopting a dynamic, flexible system and set of habits to continually access what we need without throwing our environment (and mind) into chaos."

- (iii) Syncing the contents across all platforms;
- (iv) Updating an inactive project's status before archiving it;
- (v) Evaluating how far you met your success criteria;
- (vi) Doing a post-mortem to consider what you learnt, what you did well, and how you could improve in future; and
- (vii) Communicating with your stakeholders to close the project.



Do weekly and monthly reviews of your personal and professional life to decide what to keep/change. As you do your reviews, go through the notes you created that week/month, add titles, and sort them into the PARA folders.

- Use weekly reviews to reset your digital workspaces so you won't get overwhelmed. You can clear your inboxes and computer desktop, check your calendar, and set your tasks/priorities for the week.
- Use monthly reviews for a more holistic evaluation of your ambitions, priorities and working systems. You can update your goals and project lists, review your areas of responsibilities and "someday/maybe list" to consider if there're tasks or actions that should be reprioritized.



Make mental housekeeping a part of your daily routine. Use every opportunity to notice and capture potentially useful information, then highlight, edit, and organize your notes to make them more discoverable for your future self.

- Don't accumulate mental clutter, then try to set aside time just to clear them. Instead, use your spare time or gaps in your schedule to do organize your Second Brain daily.

"It's crucial to stay organized, but it needs to be done a little at a time in the flow of our normal lives."



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book

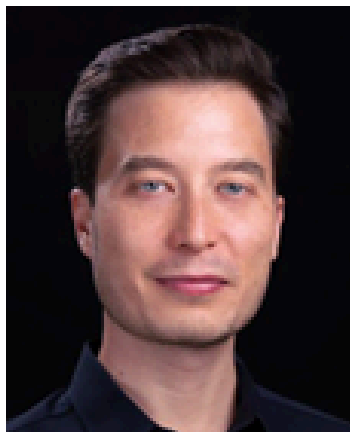
The Second Brain isn't just about finding/using the best tools. It's about freeing your brain to do what it's designed to do—to connect, innovate, learn, grow, and orchestrate your life. The more you use your Second Brain, the more it changes the way you think and see the world. You'll find yourself feeling calmer and more focused, developing greater self-awareness, and experiencing a fundamental

"The purpose of knowledge is to be shared. Knowledge is the only resource that gets better and more valuable the more it multiplies."

mindset shift (i) from scarcity to abundance, (ii) from consumption to creation, and (iii) from stress/obligation to serving and sharing with others,

The book is packed with examples and tips to help you to understand and apply the CODE Method to create and maintain your Second Brain. You can find more resources (such as the recommended tools/apps and tips for tagging) from <https://www.buildingasecondbrain.com> or <https://fortelabs.com>.

About the Author



Tiago Forte is an author, entrepreneur, and consultant, best known for his research and teachings on productivity. He's the founder of productivity consultancy and training firm Forte Labs (fortelabs.co). He has worked with many global organizations, and taught thousands of people to improve their personal effectiveness, productivity, and creativity.

KEY QUOTES